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Sixty years ago when India gained its Independence from the British, many noted scholars, writers and statesmen didn't give the young nation much of a chance of survival. The great Winston Churchill, known for his grasp of history, said: "India will fall back quite rapidly through the centuries into the barbarism and privations of the Middle Ages." Well, he was horribly wrong. India not only survived but thrived as a thriving democracy. If such things qualified as 'wonders of the world', I would declare it the eighth wonder.

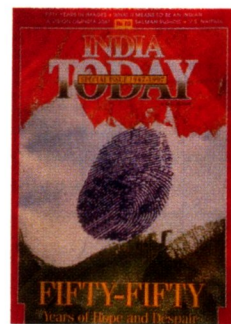
India has done what Europe has been attempting to do for the last 50 years, starting out as the European Economic Community and still not succeeded. India may be slightly smaller in size than the European Union today but has twice the population and is more diverse with many more religions, languages and cultures. We have a common currency, a Central government and have been practising the motto of the European Union 'United in Diversity' for the past 60 years.

Undoubtedly, it has not been easy. We've had linguistic agitations, separatist movements, sectarian violence, divisive politics and some abysmally inept leaders. We've had to battle poverty, centuries old traditions and superstitions and paid the price for decades of socialist style economic practices. We have endured one of the most stifling bureaucracies of the world and suffered the deeds of truly venal and hugely corrupt politicians. Former US ambassador John Kenneth Galbraith aptly described India as a "functioning anarchy". Now that India is seen by the world as a youthful, energetic, emerging global power of the 21st century and as the world's largest democracy, it is easy to forget the underpinnings of this country and the struggles to achieve it.

Therefore, for our cover story marking the 60th Anniversary of India's Independence, INDIA TODAY asked some of the finest writers and scholars on India, the overtly simple but ultimately complex question: "What unites India?" Among them are eminent jurist Fali Nariman, sociologist Dipankar Gupta, Jnanpith awardee U.R. Ananthamurthy, journalist Mark Tully, all writing about the various threads that have kept the fabric of India from unravelling: from the freedom struggle to the Constitution, from democracy to spirituality, from cricket to the cinema.

'What Unites India?' is a fascinating question because, as you will find from this issue, there was no one answer. Everyone has their own hypothesis. Very much like India, where everyone has an opinion but we still call ourselves Indians. I think writer Patrick French puts it well when he says, "What unites India today is a sense of possibility." *Jai Hind.*

(Aron Purie)



Our Aug 1997 cover